

Fierce sea battle at Weihaiwei
A heroic sword-wielding officer of the Imperial Japanese Navy spurs forward his men as they fire on a Chinese warship at Weihaiwei.

CREW PROFILE

JAPANESE IMPERIAL WARSHIP

1870s TO EARLY 1900s

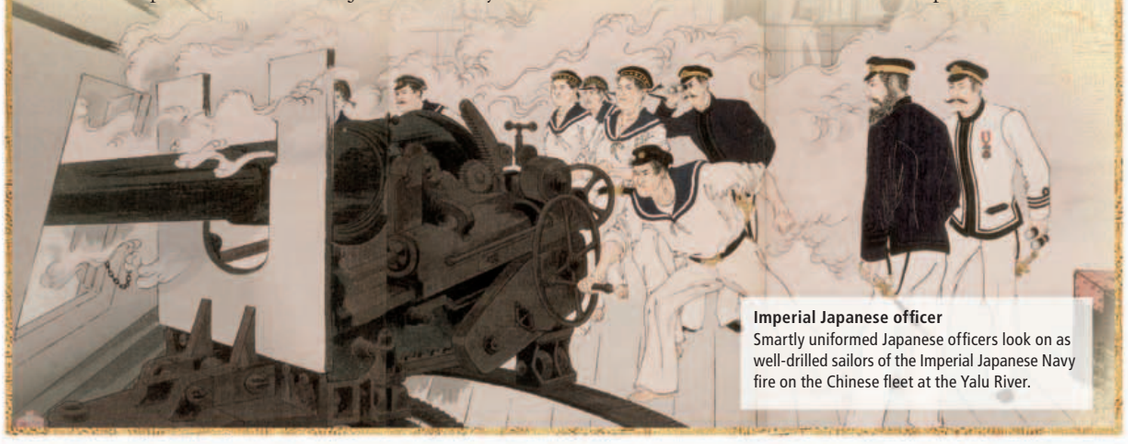
WHEN THE JAPANESE SET OUT to create the Imperial Navy almost from scratch in the 1870s, they received most of their training and ships from Britain. The result was a service in most ways similar to Western navies of the time. All ranks were uniformed and formal discipline such as saluting of officers was strictly enforced. The navy was in the forefront of the headlong modernization of Japan, well ahead of most of civil society, so it was on board ship that many Japanese recruits first got to grips with technologies such as steam engines and electricity. Discipline was often enforced with slaps or punches, but this was apparently acceptable to the average Japanese sailor, brought up in an ordered and disciplined society.

OFFICER CLASS

Commissioned officers were more numerous in the steam era than in the age of sail, and more diverse. Many were given responsibility for specialist areas, such as gunnery, engines, or torpedoes. The first wave of Japanese officers was mostly recruited from the Satsuma samurai clan, and the founding ethos of the Imperial Navy mingled the samurai tradition with attitudes and practices learned from Britain's Royal Navy. The Etajima Naval Academy soon became the route into the Japanese naval officer corps. Entrants were picked by rigorous nationwide examinations, with many more applicants than places available. Those who passed were then subjected to four years intensive training, with an emphasis on physical fitness as well as academic education. Graduates from Etajima entered the navy as a self-conscious elite.

DISCIPLINE AND AUSTERITY

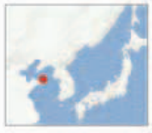
Despite holding a high sense of status and personal honor, Japanese officers tended to be frugal and spartan, sleeping on rush mats on the deck. When the men had to clean decks barefoot in freezing weather, Admiral Togo would reportedly come on deck barefoot himself. Obedience and loyalty were highly valued qualities society and transferred well to the formal hierarchical world of a warship.



Imperial Japanese officer
Smartly uniformed Japanese officers look on as well-drilled sailors of the Imperial Japanese Navy fire on the Chinese fleet at the Yalu River.

FIRST SINO-JAPANESE WAR

WEIHAIWEI



Location Shantung Peninsula, China

Date January 30–February 12,1895
Forces Japanese: 41 vessels including 16 torpedo boats; Chinese: 2 battleships, 5 cruisers, 13 torpedo boats
Losses Japanese: none; Chinese: 1 battleship, 2 cruisers, 6 torpedo boats sunk, all others captured

After the punishing battle at the Yalu River, Chinese admiral Ting Ju ch'ang withdrew his fleet to the fortified harbor at Weihaiwei. Here his turret ships, cruisers, and torpedo boats were protected by shore guns and a barrier of tethered mines and steel hawsers across the harbor mouth. The Japanese fleet arrived at the end of January 1895 to blockade the harbor while troops attacked Weihaiwei by land. The weather was appalling with prolonged blizzards and on several occasions sailors froze to death at their posts. The Japanese ships engaged in gun duels with the Chinese shore batteries and warships day and night, with no decisive results.

Seeing that they would have to enter the harbor, the Japanese carried out risky minesweeping operations and cut one of the steel hawsers. They then sent torpedo boats into the harbor several times at night, sinking the armored turret ship *Ting Yuen* and the cruisers *Ching Yuen* and *Lai Yuen*. In a desperate gesture, Admiral Ting sent all his torpedo boats out of the harbor in a daylight sortie that resulted in all of the boats being sunk or captured. By February 12 the Chinese had had enough of the extreme cold, continual bombardment, and terrifying night raids. Admiral Ting sent a surrender note to the Japanese admiral. Before the Japanese could take possession of the enemy fleet, the Chinese admiral committed suicide. Shortly after, China sought peace negotiations with Japan.